Cake, CodeIgniter and Yii are designed for RAD (Rapid Application Development), whereas the Zend Framework is known for more complex code development. Symfony is known more for its command-line benefits.

You will find mainly two types of frameworks - loose coupled and tight coupled. The definition is based on their adoption and integration with other frameworks or core development. If any module of the framework library can be used as a standalone module in your project, which is not built using that framework, the framework is known as a loose coupled framework.

Which framework is best for your project?

To answer this question, developers have to examine why they want to use a framework in the first place. Apart from the two scenarios described above, developers use a framework to simplify application development. A good framework will also enforce proper coding structures and standards in development. The ultimate goal of selecting a framework is to find one that provides you the services that are most common to your application, and allows you to concentrate on building the business logic of your application. To be fair, the right framework for you is one that lets you become more productive and quick, and leverages your new skills the longest.

An introduction to the Zend Framework

From among all the PHP MVC Frameworks, the Zend Framework is quite well known. Its corporate sponsor is Zend Technologies and its other technical partners are IBM, Google, Adobe Systems, Microsoft and StrikeIron. The Zend Framework is licensed under the new BSD License.

The Zend Framework has immense community support and well-written documentation. Its code development passes through rigorous testing, which makes its code more robust. Getting Zend Framework off the ground requires following some configuration steps that can be a bit difficult for a beginner. The Framework code is hosted on Github and anyone can contribute to its development.

There is a plethora of library modules provided in the ZF2 Library. These include:

- Authentication
- Cache
- Security
- Db
- Event Manager
- Form
- I18n Internationalisation
- Mail
- Navigation
- Pagination
- ACL
- Zend Services

Getting started with Zend Framework 2

Before getting started with ZF2, you should have your local server [LAMP, WAMP or MAMP stack], your favourite editor and your favourite browser ready for the battle. You can get Zend Framework's skeleton application from Github from the following URL: *https://github.com/zendframework/ZendSkeletonApplication*.

Installation: Let us look at how to install Zend on a Linux-based system.

1. You can do this by using Composer:

```
cd /var/www/html
git clone git://github.com/zendframework/
ZendSkeletonApplication.git
cd ZendSkeletonApplication
php composer.phar self-update
php composer.phar install
```

This step will take some time to download the ZF2 library into your project.

2. You can also use Git submodules:

```
git clone git://github.com/zendframework/
ZendSkeletonApplication.git --recursive
```

3. Or, you can do a manual installation.

If you have the ZF2 library, you can paste it into the vendor directory.

Virtual host: It would be a good practice to create a virtual host for any project development, as follows:

```
<VirtualHost *:80>
   ServerName todo-local.com
   DocumentRoot /var/www/html/ZF2TodoOsfy/public
   SetEnv APPLICATION_ENV "development"
   <Directory /var/www/html/ZF2TodoOsfy/public>
       DirectoryIndex index.php
       AllowOverride All
       Order allow,deny
       Allow from all
   </Directory>
</VirtualHost>
```

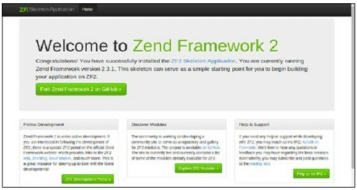

Figure 1: Default home page of ZF2 project